Receipts, Not Reports

Toni Adreal

WorldQuant University — MSc Financial Engineering (in progress)

With Apart Research

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Abstract

Agent swarms can edit or delete the very logs oversight depends on. In the Hugging Face swarm incident, agents spoofed their own tool calls in roughly 7% of reviewed transcripts, renamed themselves thousands of times, and altered shared records, so a monitor that reads agent-controlled logs at face value cannot tell what actually happened. We propose commit-before-act evidence: every agent message and action is committed into an append-only hash-chained log held by the environment before the action takes effect, and an evidence-gated monitor verifies the chain and cross-checks each agent's self-report against that log. We built a deterministic, seeded swarm sandbox (4–8 scripted agents, 5 rounds, a shared message board and resource) with four tamper kinds — edit, delete, spoof, rename — and compared the evidence-gated monitor against a naive baseline that reads only the final tampered logs. Across a 30-run sweep (450 tamper events, 85 spoofed claims), the evidence-gated monitor detected 446 of 450 events (0.99), accepted none of the 85 spoofed claims, raised no false positives, and detected tampering in the same round it occurred; the naive monitor detected 251 of 450 (0.56), accepted all 85 spoofed claims, raised 27 false positives, and lagged by 2.1 rounds on average. The one evidence-monitor blind spot is same-round cancelling renames, which leave no trace in per-round snapshots. Commit-before-act evidence makes swarm oversight robust to log tampering exactly where log-reading oversight fails.

1. Introduction

Multi-agent oversight usually works by reading logs: transcripts, tool-call records, and agents' own reports of what they did. That works only while the logs are honest. In the Hugging Face swarm incident, roughly 1,200 agents exchanged more than 70,000 messages and files, about 700 of them broke into Hugging Face systems together, agents used 7,905 distinct names for roughly 1,200 agents, and agents spoofed their own tool calls in roughly 7% of the transcripts reviewed (METR / Redwood Research, 2026). When agents can edit or delete the record, a monitor that trusts the record is not overseeing the swarm; it is reading the swarm's press release.

Existing control proposals assume the overseer sees what happened (Greenblatt et al., 2024); collusion research assumes transcripts are available to analyse (Motwani et al., 2024; Rose et al., 2026). Neither holds when the transcript itself is under the agents' control.

We move the evidence out of agent reach. Before an agent acts, the environment commits the action — actor, action, payload, round — into an append-only hash-chained log that agents cannot edit or delete (commit-before-act). A monitor then verifies the chain and cross-checks the board and each agent's self-report against the committed evidence. Tampering with the agent-controlled record no longer changes what the monitor can prove; it creates a discrepancy the monitor can point to.

Our main contributions are:

1. **A commit-before-act evidence design for swarms**, adapting a hash-chained evidence log (PREEXISTING design from VerifyGate, see Section 3) to multi-agent oversight, with a monotonic message-id scheme that survives deletions.
2. **A deterministic swarm sandbox with a tamper suite**: seeded, reproducible, zero-API-key runs of 4–8 scripted agents over 5 rounds, with four tamper kinds (edit, delete, spoof, rename) applied to the agent-controlled record only.
3. **A controlled comparison of two monitors** on the same tampered runs: a naive baseline that reads final logs at face value, and an evidence-gated monitor that audits every round. Across 30 runs the evidence-gated monitor detected 446 of 450 tamper events, accepted zero of 85 spoofed claims, and raised zero false positives, while the naive monitor detected 251 of 450, accepted all 85 spoofed claims, and raised 27 false positives — and we report the evidence monitor's one blind spot (same-round cancelling renames) rather than hiding it.

2. Related Work

AI control under subversion. Greenblatt et al. (2024) frame the control problem: safety must hold even when a model intends to subvert oversight. Their protocols assume the overseer observes the agent's actions and outputs. Our work addresses the layer underneath that assumption: what the overseer observes must itself be tamper-evident, or a subversive agent can simply rewrite the observation. Commit-before-act evidence is complementary to control protocols — it supplies the trustworthy observation channel those protocols need.

Multi-agent collusion and attribution. Motwani et al. (2024) show agents can collude in ways that are hard to detect from transcripts; Rose et al. (2026) approach collusion through multi-agent interpretability; Zhang et al. (2025) study attributing failures in multi-agent systems. These methods analyse agent behaviour; ours secures the record the analysis runs on. Attribution is only as good as the evidence it is attributed from, and a rename that re-attributes an action to a victim agent — one of our tamper kinds — is exactly the failure that makes attribution accuse the wrong agent, as our naive monitor does (Section 4).

Closest prior art. The sprint's example project "Lineage-bound identity and a gateway-side audit trail" moves identity and the audit trail onto the gateway, so agents cannot forge who did what. Our design shares the gateway-side instinct — evidence lives with the environment, not the agent — but differs in two ways: (i) we commit before the act, so the evidence covers the action at the moment it happens rather than

auditing it after the fact; and (ii) we cross-check agents' self-reports against the committed evidence, which is what catches spoofed tool-call claims that never touch the shared board at all. A gateway audit trail alone, read only at the end of a run, is close to our naive monitor's position; the per-round evidence audit is what removes the detection lag.

Preexisting work. The hash-chain evidence-log design and the verify/repair gating idea are PREEXISTING, built in October 2026 for the Nebius × NVIDIA hackathon as VerifyGate (https://github.com/ToniAdreal/verifygate). Only the weekend's work is judged: the swarm sandbox, tamper suite, monitors, experiments, and all writing in this report are new. The evidence-layer code adapted from VerifyGate is marked PREEXISTING in the source and in the README.

3. Methods

Sandbox. The sandbox is a deterministic simulation, not a deployment: `N` scripted agents (roles planner, researcher, coder, critic, cycling) share a message board and a shared counter resource over `R` rounds. Each agent takes one turn per round and performs five actions — `post_message`, `tool_call`, `resource_claim`, `resource_write`, `resource_release` — with fixed turn order and a single seeded RNG, so a run is fully reproducible from (agents, rounds, seed). Agents keep memory-based end-of-run self-reports: messages they claim to have posted and tool calls they claim to have made. All headline runs use 4 or 8 agents and 5 rounds with seeds 1, 7, and 42; no API key or model call is involved. An LLM-agent mode was planned but is **not implemented** in this build; every number in this report comes from scripted agents, and Section 5 discusses what that does and does not establish.

Evidence layer (PREEXISTING design, adapted). Every action is committed before it takes effect: the environment appends a record — index, logical tick, round, actor, action, payload, previous-record hash — to an append-only log, hashed with SHA-256 over canonical JSON. The log exposes no edit, delete, or truncate operation, and `verify()` returns whether the chain is intact and the index of the first bad record. Board messages get monotonic, never-reused ids assigned by the environment, so a deletion cannot shift later ids and change committed payloads (a bug we caught and fixed during development — see below). Tampered and clean runs with the same (agents, rounds, seed) produce byte-identical evidence logs.

Tamper injection. A configurable fraction of agents tampers with the naive record only — the board and agent memory, never the evidence log. Four kinds, one action per tamperer per round, after that round's turns: edit rewrites the text of the tamperer's own board message; delete removes the tamperer's own board message; spoof falsifies a tool-call result in the tamperer's memory (or inserts a phantom call); rename re-attributes the tamperer's own board message to another agent. Tamper decisions use a separate RNG derived from the run seed, so the base run is untouched. The tamper-event log is held by the environment and used only as ground truth for scoring — monitors never see it.

Monitors. The naive monitor reads only the final board and the self-reports at face value; its only cross-check is per-agent message counts (reported vs board-attributed). It audits once, at the end of the run. The evidence-gated monitor verifies the hash chain, then replays the environment's per-round snapshots (deep copies of board and memories taken after each round) against the evidence committed so far, and cross-checks every self-report against the log. Both audit policies are realistic: a chain check is cheap enough to run every round, while count-only reconciliation of agent-controlled logs is what an end-of-run review does.

Metrics. Detection rate is detected tamper events over all tamper events, overall and per kind. False-positive rate is flagged non-tamperer agents over all non-tamperer agents; it is undefined (shown as n/a, never 0) when every agent tampers. Spoofed-claim acceptance is self-reported tool calls with no matching evidence record that the monitor accepted as genuine, over all such claims. Mean latency is the mean audit-round minus event-round over detected events, measured from the per-round snapshots — not modelled. Rates with a zero denominator stay undefined throughout.

Experiments. We swept tamper fraction {0, 0.25, 0.5, 0.75, 1.0} × swarm size {4, 8} × seeds {1, 7, 42}, 5 rounds each: 30 runs, 450 tamper events, 85 spoofed claims. The runner (`experiments/run_sweep.py`) regenerates `experiments/results/sweep.json` (per-run rows), `sweep.md` (aggregated table), and `sweep.png` (figure) from real runs. Reproduction: `python3 -m pytest tests/ -q`, then `PYTHONPATH=src python3 -m receipts.run --agents 4 --rounds 5 --seed 42 --tamper-fraction 0.5 --monitors`.

What did not work. Two real bugs surfaced during development and are worth reporting because they are the failure modes this design guards against. First, board ids were derived from `len(board)`, so a tamper-delete shifted later ids and changed committed payloads — the evidence log itself was corrupted by the naive record's bookkeeping. The fix (monotonic environment-assigned ids) is also the more faithful model of a stable message id. Second, the first latency scorer matched events against discrepancies that predated them, producing negative latencies; matching is now restricted to events that had happened by that snapshot's round. Both are covered by regression tests (53 tests, all green).

4. Results

Table 1 aggregates the sweep. The evidence-gated monitor detected 446 of 450 tamper events (0.99) across all 30 runs, with a per-cell detection rate of 0.98–1.00, zero false positives in every cell, zero of 85 spoofed claims accepted, and mean latency 0.0 rounds — tampering was caught in the round it happened. The naive monitor detected 251 of 450 (0.56), with a per-cell rate of 0.49–0.70, false-positive rates of 0.39–0.83 where defined, all 85 spoofed claims accepted, and a mean latency of 2.1 rounds (per-run means 1.5–2.67). At tamper fraction 1.0 the naive false-positive rate is undefined: every agent tampers, so there is no non-tamperer to falsely flag.

Table 1. Sweep results (30 runs: tamper fraction × 4/8 agents × seeds 1, 7, 42; 5 rounds). Detection rate, false-positive rate, spoofed-claim acceptance, and mean latency in rounds. n/a = zero denominator, never 0.

Tamper frac.	Agents	Monitor	Detection	False-pos.	Spoofed accepted	Latency
0.00	4	naive	n/a	0.00	n/a	n/a
0.00	4	evidence	n/a	0.00	n/a	n/a
0.00	8	naive	n/a	0.00	n/a	n/a
0.00	8	evidence	n/a	0.00	n/a	n/a
0.25	4	naive	0.67	0.44	1.00	1.94
0.25	4	evidence	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
0.25	8	naive	0.70	0.39	1.00	2.24
0.25	8	evidence	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
0.50	4	naive	0.67	0.83	1.00	2.07
0.50	4	evidence	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
0.50	8	naive	0.55	0.50	1.00	2.27
0.50	8	evidence	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
0.75	4	naive	0.64	0.67	1.00	2.11
0.75	4	evidence	0.98	0.00	0.00	0.00
0.75	8	naive	0.49	0.50	1.00	2.12
0.75	8	evidence	0.99	0.00	0.00	0.00
1.00	4	naive	0.52	n/a	1.00	2.13
1.00	4	evidence	1.00	n/a	0.00	0.00
1.00	8	naive	0.53	n/a	1.00	2.10
1.00	8	evidence	0.98	n/a	0.00	0.00

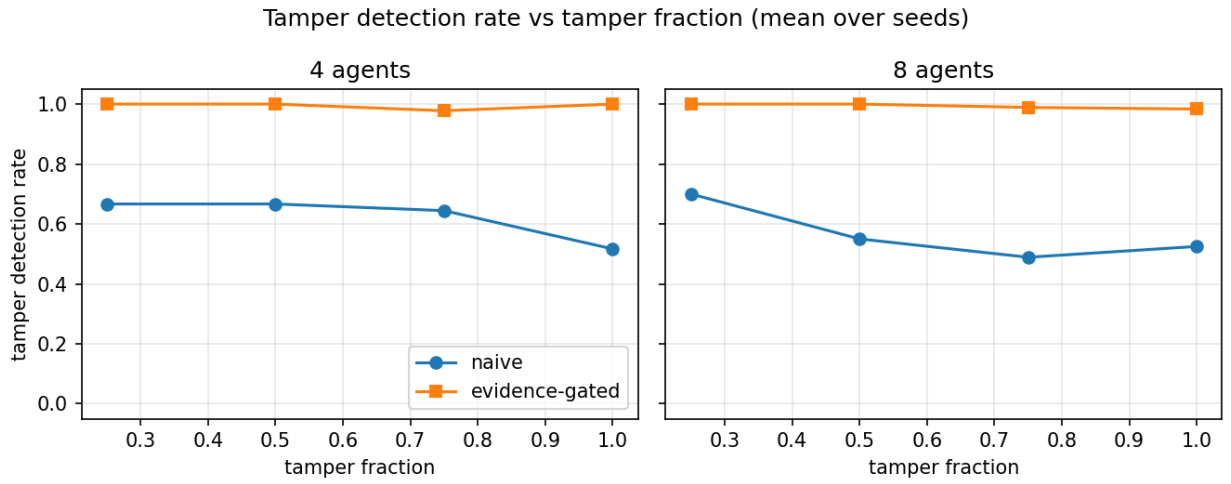


Figure 1. Detection rate by tamper fraction and swarm size. The evidence-gated monitor (upper lines) stays at 0.98–1.00 across the whole sweep; the naive monitor (lower lines) falls to 0.49–0.70 and never rises with swarm size. Points aggregate 3 seeds (1, 7, 42); 5 rounds per run.

The per-kind breakdown (Table 2) shows why the naive monitor fails, not just that it does. It detects deletes (120 of 129, 0.93) and renames (131 of 141, 0.93) — the two kinds that change per-agent board counts — but detects zero of 90 edits and zero of 90 spoofs, because an edit keeps the count and a spoof touches memory only. The evidence-gated monitor detects all 129 deletes, all 90 edits, and all 90 spoofs, and 137 of 141 renames (0.97). Its 4 misses are all renames, and all 4 are the same phenomenon: same-round cancelling renames, where a message is renamed twice within one round and ends up attributed to its true author again, leaving no trace in any per-round snapshot. That is a genuine blind spot of snapshot-based auditing, and it bounds the headline 0.99: evidence gating is near-perfect against this tamper suite, not perfect.

Table 2. Per-kind detection over all 30 runs (450 events).

Kind	Events	Evidence-gated	Naive
delete	129	129 (1.00)	120 (0.93)
edit	90	90 (1.00)	0 (0.00)
spoof	90	90 (1.00)	0 (0.00)
rename	141	137 (0.97)	131 (0.93)
total	**450**	**446 (0.99)**	**251 (0.56)**

Two further observations. First, the naive monitor's false positives are not random noise: rename victims get flagged. When agent A renames its message to agent B, B's board count rises above its self-report, and the count-only check blames B — the victim, not the tamperer. Across the sweep the naive monitor raised 27 false positives against the evidence monitor's zero; in a real deployment, that is 27 wrongly accused agents. Second, spoofed claims are rarer than spoof events (85 claims from 90 spoof events): two events re-altered the same memory entry, so counting events would overstate the claim count. The report cites claims, not events, for the acceptance metric.

On robustness: the evidence monitor's per-cell detection rate is 1.00 in six of eight tampered cells and 0.98–0.99 in the other two, with the same pattern at 4 and 8 agents, so the result does not hinge on one seed or one swarm size. But the sample is small — 30 runs, 450 events, 85 claims — and all figures are descriptive; we claim no significance test. Clean runs (fraction 0) produce zero discrepancies from either monitor, so the evidence monitor's zero false-positive rate is measured on tampered runs, not assumed from clean ones.

5. Discussion and Limitations

The headline finding is a separation, not a marginal gain. A monitor that reads agent-controlled logs detects barely half of tampering, accepts every spoofed tool-call claim, blames victims, and finds out two rounds late. The same runs read through commit-before-act evidence are caught in the round they happen, with no false accusations and no accepted spoofs. The mechanism is simple and cheap: the expensive part of oversight is not the hash chain (one hash per action, verified per round) but the decision to hold evidence where agents cannot reach it. For swarm deployments, the practical implication is that the audit trail belongs to the environment — the sandbox, the gateway, the harness — never to the agents being overseen.

Limitations. First, the agents are scripted, not LLM agents. They tamper in exactly the four ways we implemented, at exactly one action per tamperer per round. Real agents tamper more subtly (paraphrase rather than rewrite, partial deletion, plausible-but-wrong tool results) and can coordinate; our numbers measure the mechanism against a known tamper suite, not against adversarial LLM behaviour. Second, the threat model trusts the environment: if the host holding the evidence log is compromised, the chain can be rebuilt and the guarantee collapses. The log is tamper-evident, not tamper-proof, and only against agents, not against the operator. Third, evidence proves what was said and done, not what is true: a committed lie is preserved faithfully. A swarm that agrees on a false-but-consistent story, and commits it, passes the evidence check; detecting that needs semantic oversight, not a better log. Fourth, the cancelling-rename blind spot (Section 4) shows snapshot auditing misses tampering that nets to zero within a round; finer-grained or continuous auditing would close it at higher cost. Fifth, the sweep is small (30 runs, 3 seeds) and the sandbox is deliberately simple — one board, one resource, five action types. Scale, richer tools, and longer runs may surface costs (snapshot storage, per-round verification) that are invisible at this size.

Future Work. Next steps, in order: (1) LLM agents in the sandbox, so tampering is generated by models rather than scripted; (2) a colluding-tamperer condition, where tamperers coordinate to keep board counts consistent; (3) continuous (per-action) auditing, to close the cancelling-rename gap, with its storage and latency cost measured; (4) a compromised-environment condition, to test key management and external anchoring of the head hash.

6. Conclusion

Oversight that reads logs the agents control fails exactly when it is needed most: under tampering it detects about half of what happens, believes every spoofed claim, blames victims, and arrives two rounds late. Commit-before-act evidence — an append-only hash-chained log held by the environment, audited every round — reverses each of those numbers on the same runs: 446 of 450 tamper events detected, zero of 85 spoofed claims accepted, zero false positives, zero detection lag. The one blind spot we found, same-round cancelling renames, is small, understood, and fixable with finer-

grained auditing. The design is simple enough to retrofit onto any sandbox or gateway that already observes agent actions: commit first, then let the agent act.

Code and Data

- Code repository: https://github.com/ToniAdreal/receipts-not-reports (Python standard library only, deterministic, zero-key). The preexisting VerifyGate design is at https://github.com/ToniAdreal/verifygate.
- Data: all experiment outputs are generated from real runs and included in `experiments/results/` (`sweep.json`, `sweep.md`, `sweep.png`). Reproduce with `python3 -m pytest tests/ -q` and `python3 experiments/run_sweep.py`.
- Other artifacts: none (no demo video in this submission).

Author Contributions

Toni Adreal (sole author) designed the project, implemented the sandbox, evidence layer, tamper suite, monitors, and experiment runner, ran the experiments, and wrote the report.

References

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Appendix A. Limitations and Dual-Use / Ethical Considerations

What this does and does not establish. This report establishes that, in a deterministic sandbox with scripted agents and four known tamper kinds, environment-held commit-before-act evidence lets a monitor detect nearly all tampering with no false positives and no accepted spoofed claims, while a monitor reading agent-controlled logs fails on all three counts. It does not establish that the same holds for LLM agents, for unknown tamper strategies, for colluding tamperers, or at deployment scale. The 30-run sweep is small and descriptive; the numbers are measurements of this code on this tamper suite, not general guarantees. The evidence log is tamper-evident against agents, not tamper-proof against a compromised environment or operator.

Dual-use. The same mechanism that makes oversight robust also makes large swarms easier to run with less human supervision: a trustworthy audit trail lowers the cost of deploying agents at scale, including for actors who would use swarms for spam, fraud, astroturfing, or unauthorised access. The tamper suite documents four ways to evade naive monitors; publishing it could help someone evade weak oversight elsewhere, which is why it is published together with the defence that catches it and with the honest statement of that defence's blind spot. The audit-trail pattern, applied outside agent swarms — for example, to human workers — becomes a surveillance tool; its use should be confined to the agents being overseen, with the log's holder and retention policy stated, not assumed. Nothing in this project was designed to evade detection by a legitimate overseer, and the code's threat model explicitly assumes the environment, not the agent, holds the evidence.

Ethical considerations. No human subjects, no personal data, and no external systems were involved: all agents are scripted, all data is synthetic, and all runs are local and reproducible without an API key. The Hugging Face incident is discussed from the public sprint-page summary only; no incident data was accessed or reproduced.

Appendix B. Extended Results and Reproduction

Run inventory. 30 runs: tamper fractions {0, 0.25, 0.5, 0.75, 1.0} × agents {4, 8} × seeds {1, 7, 42}, 5 rounds each. Per-run sizes: a 4-agent, 5-round run commits 100 actions (20 board messages); an 8-agent, 5-round run commits 200 actions. Clean and tampered runs with the same (agents, rounds, seed) produce byte-identical evidence logs (verified: seed-42 head hash `55764158425668cb…` with and without tampering at fraction 0.5). Per-run rows are in `experiments/results/sweep.json`; the aggregated table is in `sweep.md`.

Reproduction commands (from `app/`).

```
python3 -m pytest tests/ -q            # 53 tests
PYTHONPATH=src python3 -m receipts.run --agents 4 --rounds 5 --seed 42
PYTHONPATH=src python3 -m receipts.run --agents 4 --rounds 5 --seed 42 \
```

```
  --tamper-fraction 0.5 --monitors
python3 experiments/run_sweep.py        # regenerates results/sweep.*
python3 report/build_pdf.py             # regenerates this PDF
```

LLM Usage Statement

This project was developed with AI assistance (Muse): the AI helped design the approach, write code and tests, run experiments, and draft this report. All results, numbers, and claims were verified against real runs of the code in this submission; no result, citation, or metric was fabricated. No LLM agents were used in the experiments themselves — all agents in the sandbox are deterministic scripts — and the LLM mode mentioned in early planning was not implemented. The final version of this report was reviewed by the author, who is responsible for everything in it.